

[FLORENTINA]

A TYPEFACE FOR LONG TEXT SETTING

The 13th of September 2001 was announced by some English newspapers as a day of prayer following the attack, two days earlier, on the twin towers of the World Trade Centre in New York. Prayer for many people on this day was implicit and perhaps even wordless.

EVERY GENERATION FINDS NEW WAYS TO CONFRONT and express the feelings they have in common. The forms of service and worship of the Church of England were theoretically fixed in The Book of Common Prayer (BCP, sometimes known as '1662'). Common' distinguishes the prayers gathered in this book from those said in private. However, liturgy continues to develop, and experimentation with new forms of service culminated in the Alternative Service Book of 1980 (ASB). With experience of its use, the weaknesses as well as the strengths of the ASB became apparent. Through its governing body the General Synod, the Church began to revise the ASB. The result was Common Worship – 'services which bring together the best of both ancient and modern, classic and contemporary'. From 1 January 2001 the Church of England has had two sets of liturgies for worship: those in The Book of Common Prayer (which remains permanently authorized) and the new services in Common Worship. The full title Common Worship: Services and Prayers for the Church of England, tells us this much: first, it is more than one main service book, it is a collection of resources published in books, booklets, cards, on computer disks and available free on the internet; second 'common prayer' (that is, shared forms of worship) expresses the unity in the wider Church of England while allowing for variety and local responsibility. Common Worship was designed to be used across the whole breadth of the Church of England. The process of producing Common Worship was exhaustive and involved all parts of the church, starting with the Liturgical Commission, which produced the first drafts. These went to the House of Bishops, which amended the texts and sent them to the General Synod, where representatives of the clergy and laity, with the bishops, debated the drafts. Revision committees then considered and amended the drafts in response to the debates in Synod. When revision was complete the House of Bishops again considered the texts. Finally the General Synod voted on the final form of the services. The authorization dates were set and the process of publication began. In contrast to the ASB which was published by a consortium of publishers, Common Worship was published by Church House Publishing, the Church of England's in-house publisher. With the advantages of production under one roof and with no shareholders, prices were kept as low as possible (the standard edition was published at '15). The ASB had already abandoned the official dress of the bluebook' precedents of the privileged presses. 6

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